



UNITED STATES DEPARTMENT OF EDUCATION
OFFICE OF ELEMENTARY AND SECONDARY EDUCATION

January 15, 2025

The Honorable Russell D. Johnston
Acting Commissioner
Massachusetts Department of Elementary and Secondary Education
135 Santilli Highway
Everett, MA 02149

Dear Acting Commissioner Johnston:

I am writing in response to the Massachusetts Department of Elementary and Secondary Education's (DESE's) request to the U.S. Department of Education (Department) to amend its approved consolidated State plan under the Elementary and Secondary Education Act of 1965 (ESEA). Massachusetts first submitted its request on August 30, 2024, and submitted a revised version on October 23, 2024.

After consulting with the Office of English Language Acquisition, I have determined that the amendment requests meet ESEA requirements; accordingly, I am approving Massachusetts' amended State plan. A summary of Massachusetts' amendment is enclosed. This letter, as well as Massachusetts' revised ESEA consolidated State plan, will be posted on the Department's website. Any further requests to amend Massachusetts' ESEA consolidated State plan must be submitted to the Department for review and approval.

Please be aware that approval of this amendment is not a determination that all the information and data included in the amended State plan comply with Federal civil rights requirements, including Title VI of the Civil Rights Act of 1964, Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972, Section 504 of the Rehabilitation Act of 1973, Title II of the Americans with Disabilities Act, and requirements under the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act. It is Massachusetts' responsibility to comply with these civil rights requirements.

Thank you for the work DESE has invested in its consolidated State plan under the ESEA. If you need any assistance regarding its implementation, please contact the Office of School Support and Accountability at OESE.TitleI-a@ed.gov.

Sincerely,

/s/

Adam Schott
Principal Deputy Assistant Secretary
Delegated the Authority to Perform the
Functions and Duties of the Assistant Secretary
Office of Elementary and Secondary Education

400 MARYLAND AVE., SW, WASHINGTON, DC 20202
<http://www.ed.gov/>

The Department of Education's mission is to promote student achievement and preparation for global competitiveness by fostering educational excellence and ensuring equal access.

Enclosure

cc: Erica Gonzalez, Massachusetts Department of Elementary and Secondary Education
Rob Curtin, Massachusetts Department of Elementary and Secondary Education

Amendments to the Massachusetts' Consolidated State Plan

The following is a summary of the Massachusetts' Department of Elementary and Secondary Education's (DESE's) amendment request. Please refer to the Department's website (<https://www.ed.gov/about/ed-offices/oese/key-documents>) for Massachusetts' complete consolidated State plan.

Title I, Part A: Improving Basic Programs Operated by Local Educational Agencies (LEAs)

- *Long-Term Goals – Academic Achievement and Graduation Rate*
DESE updated its baseline data to use 2022 State assessment results, measurements of interim progress, and long-term goals through the 2026-2027 school year for academic achievement. Student groups who experienced the largest declines in student achievement from 2019-2022 are required to make the largest annual gains towards the long-term goals.
- *Long-Term Goals – Graduation Rate*
DESE updated its baseline data to use the 2020-2021 school year adjusted cohort graduation rate (ACGR), measurements of interim progress, and long-term goals for graduation rate through 2025-2026.
- *Long-Term Goals – English Language Proficiency*
DESE updated its baseline data to 2021-2022 and revised its measurements of interim progress and long-term goals through the 2026-2027 school year for progress in achieving English language proficiency (ELP). DESE established separate measurements of interim progress and long-term goals for high-schools and non-high schools.

In addition, DESE updated its timeline for a student to become proficient in English from six years to five years. DESE will set individual student progress targets based on the student's baseline score and the progress needed to reach proficiency in five years.

- *Native Language Assessments*
DESE clarified that the high school Next Generation Massachusetts Comprehensive Assessment System (MCAS) mathematics and science and technology/engineering (STE) assessments are available in both English and Spanish. The State is gathering input to determine if it will procure assessments in other languages or develop Spanish translations for assessments in additional grades in the future.
- *Student Groups*
DESE revised the labels it uses for some student groups (e.g., Native American to American Indian or Alaska Native), but did not change student groups included in its accountability system.
- *Academic Achievement Indicator*
DESE included its Next Generation MCAS reading/language arts (R/LA) and mathematics scaled score achievement level ranges for grades 3-8 and 10 in its Academic Achievement indicator. DESE continues to use its previously-approved methodology for calculating the indicator. DESE clarified that the denominator of the Academic Achievement indicator calculation is the higher of either the number of students meeting the partial attendance requirement with a completed test or 95 percent of such students. This applies to all student groups.

- *Other Academic Indicator for Public Elementary and Secondary Schools that are Not High Schools*

DESE updated the scale score ranges for its performance levels for the Next Generation science assessment in grades 5 and 8 that it uses for its Other Academic indicator for public elementary schools and secondary schools that are not high schools. It made no other changes to how it calculates this indicator.

- *Progress in Achieving ELP Indicator*

DESE revised its Progress in Achieving ELP indicator to consist only of students who meet the State's definition for attaining progress on the ELP assessment. The State removed the component that included students who scored proficient or above on the ELP assessment.

- *School Quality and Student Success (SQSS) Indicator*

DESE updated the scale score ranges for its performance levels for the Next Generation science assessment in grade 10 that it uses for its science achievement SQSS indicator.

DESE removed its Success in Grade 9 Courses SQSS indicator.

Finally, DESE revised its Successful Completion of Broad and Challenging Coursework indicator to clarify that the indicator measures the percentage of all students enrolled in grades 11 and 12 who complete at least one State-defined advanced course (e.g., Advanced Placement, International Baccalaureate, honors, dual enrollment, etc.).

- *Annual Meaningful Differentiation (AMD)*

DESE revised its system of AMD to differentiate schools by grade span (i.e., non-high schools, serving a combination of grades 3-8; middle-high and K-12 schools serving one or more grades 3 through 8 and grade 10; and high schools) and modified the weights of each indicator.

Specifically:

1. For non-high schools with English learners (ELs), DESE reduced the weight of the Academic Achievement indicator and increased the weight of the SQSS indicator.
2. For non-high schools without ELs, the State increased the weights for its Academic Achievement and SQSS indicators and reduced the Other Academic indicator weight.
3. For high schools with ELs, DESE increased the weights of its Graduation Rate, Progress in Achieving ELP, and SQSS indicators and reduced the Academic Achievement indicator weight.
4. For high schools without ELs, DESE increased the weights of the Graduation Rate and SQSS indicators and decreased the Academic Achievement indicator weight.

DESE also clarified that it uses three years of data in the calculation for accountability, with the most recent year receiving the greatest weight (i.e., for accountability determinations in fall 2025, data from the 2024-2025 school year is weighted at 60 percent, data from the 2022-2023 school year is weighted at 25 percent, and data from the 2021-2022 school year is weighted at 15 percent).

- *Including All Public Schools in a State's Accountability System – Alternate Methodology*

DESE clarified its alternate methodology for schools with variant grade configurations. Specifically, a school that serves a combination of grades 3-8 and 10 will receive an overall

determination based on the performance of each non-high school and high school indicator, measured separately within each grade span.

- *School Identification Methodology – Comprehensive Support and Improvement (CSI) – Low Performing*
DESE clarified that it identifies the lowest-performing five percent of Title I schools for CSI-Low performing.
- *School Identification Methodology – CSI – Low Graduation Rate*
DESE revised the threshold for identifying a high school for CSI-Low graduation rate from 67 to 66.7 percent, and clarified that high schools are identified for CSI-Low graduation rate based on the most recent four-year ACGR data.
- *School Identification Methodology – CSI – Not Exiting*
DESE clarified that only Title I schools that do not exit status as an additional targeted support and improvement (ATSI) school are eligible to be identified for CSI-Not exiting after a period of three years.
- *School Identification Methodology – Targeted Support and Improvement-Consistently Underperforming Subgroups (TSI)*
DESE clarified that it annually identifies schools for TSI using two consecutive years of data.
- *Exit Criteria – CSI*
DESE modified its exit criteria for CSI-Low performing schools to remove the requirement that the CSI school submit exit assurances (i.e., an application that describes the activities that the school intends to sustain and the mechanism or funding source that will be used to support each activity) and added the requirement that the school maintain a 95 percent participation rate on the statewide assessments (MCAS). All other exit criteria for these schools remain the same.
- *Exit Criteria – ATSI*
DESE modified its exit criteria such that an ATSI school is eligible to exit after three years if it meets each of five criteria:
 1. The school demonstrates improvement in student group performance such that the student group leading to identification is no longer among the lowest performing five percent of student groups statewide;
 2. The identified student group demonstrates improvement in academic achievement or growth since the year that the school was initially identified;
 3. The identified student group no longer demonstrates performance below that of the fifth percentile of Title I schools;
 4. Systems are in place to sustain progress in academic outcomes for students, as measured by the State’s monitoring site visit process; and
 5. The school assesses at least 95 percent of its students on the Next Generation MCAS assessments.

- *Other Continued Support*
DESE revised descriptions in the “other continued support” section of its plan to reflect the State’s current practices for supporting schools and LEAs identified for support and improvement including information on its school improvement grants, technical assistance, and resource allocation reviews.
- *Disproportionate Rate of Access to Educators*
DESE modified its definition of inexperienced teacher to be a teacher who has 0-2 years of experience and replaced “high quality teacher (HQT)” with “teachers who are teaching out-of-field.” DESE revised all educator equity data in appendix B and provided revised baseline data, gaps in percentage points between comparison student groups, and updated annual interim targets for eliminating the gaps in five years from the 2022-2023 until 2026-2027 school years.

Title I, Part D

- *Transitions between Correctional Facilities and Local Programs*
DESE added clarifying language describing how grant funds can be used and specifying that it will provide services to eligible State agencies for the transition between correctional facilities and local programs.
- *Program Objectives and Outcomes*
DESE revised its first program objective to include enrolling in postsecondary education, vocational education training programs, and opportunities to connect with potential employers and updated the support strategies and outcomes to align with those changes.

DESE revised its second program objective to measure improvements in literacy, numeracy, and English learner (EL) skills and updated its support strategies and outcomes to include professional development and technical assistance to support those improvements.

DESE revised its third program objective to include more specific requirements for staff training and expectations that instruction address the unique needs of students. DESE made edits to the support strategies to provide more professional development and updated the outcomes to collect records of staff professional development.

DESE added more detailed language to clarify the program goals and how it intends to measure success.

Title II, Part A

- *Certification and Licensure Systems*
DESE updated its ESEA consolidated State plan to explain that it offers teacher candidates an alternative licensure pathway in addition to its original Massachusetts Tests for Educator Licensure.
- *Educator Preparation Program Strategies*
DESE updated its description of the role of equity in teacher and principal preparation programs. DESE also clarified how it assesses candidates for teaching and principal licenses.

- *Educator Evaluation System*
DESE added an emphasis on equity and anti-racism as important criteria for assessing teachers and principals. It also describes how the evaluation systems for teachers and principals have been updated.
- *Resources to Support State-level Strategies*
DESE updated its ESEA consolidated State plan to clarify that its professional development activities must be aligned with the State's updated curriculum frameworks.

In addition, DESE added a description of its efforts to ensure LEAs identify and remediate equity issues related to whether disadvantaged students have access to effective educators. Finally, DESE provided supplemental data to bolster the rationale for the equity-focused strategies it is carrying out.

- *Educator Equity*
DESE provided supplemental data to bolster the rationale for the equity-focused strategies it is carrying out.

Title III, Part A

- *Entrance and Exit Procedures*
DESE updated the requirements for exiting EL status. Specifically, DESE updated the composite score from 5.0 to 4.2 and the literacy score from 4.5 to 3.9.

DESE also updated the exit criteria for ELs with the most significant cognitive disabilities.

Title VII, Subtitle B of the McKinney-Vento Homeless Assistance Act: Education for Homeless Children and Youth

- *Student Identification*
DESE provided additional detail regarding the identification training and resources available to LEAs to support the needs of students experiencing homelessness.
- *Dispute Resolution*
DESE provided additional homeless enrollment dispute resolution data.
- *Support for School Personnel*
DESE provided additional detail regarding its LEA monitoring schedule and SEA efforts to increase representation through liaisons and more interagency coordination.
- *Access to Services*
DESE highlighted collaborative efforts to support scholarships and other education resources for children and youth experiencing homelessness. It provided additional detail about strategies for ensuring that homeless children and youth have access to healthy meals, including during the pandemic and through a State-funded meal program.

- *Assistance from Counselors*
DESE provided additional detail regarding its collaboration strategies to meet the requirement of assistance from counselors to support students experiencing homelessness for college and career readiness.